



THIS HERE'S MISS BONNIE PARKER. I'M CLYDE BARROW. WE ROB BANKS

BONNIE AND CLYDE / 1967

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Crime thriller

DIRECTOR

Arthur Penn

WRITERS

**David Newman,
Robert Benton**

STARS

**Warren Beatty, Faye
Dunaway, Gene Hackman**

BEFORE

1965 Arthur Penn and Warren Beatty team up for the first time with the Chicago-set thriller *Mickey One*.

AFTER

1970 Faye Dunaway stars opposite Dustin Hoffman in Penn's Western *Little Big Man*.

1976 In Penn's *The Missouri Breaks*, Marlon Brando stars as a ruthless lawman on the trail of a gang of horse rustlers led by Jack Nicholson.

Bonnie and Clyde marked the arrival of a new generation of American directors whose freer style of filmmaking was a departure from the old studio conventions of classical Hollywood. Expensive productions such as *Cleopatra* had flopped, bankrupting the old Hollywood studio system, which loosened the studios' grip on production. Desperate financial times meant greater creative freedom, and everything about *Bonnie and Clyde*, from the movie's frequent use of unsettling close-ups to its jagged editing style, was designed to upset the status quo of traditional filmmaking.

Arthur Penn's story of a young couple on a bank-robbing rampage, based on the real-life crime spree of Clyde Barrow and Bonnie Parker between 1932 and 1934, exhibits a more realistic violence than had previously been seen on screen. It also treats its outlaw protagonists sympathetically, giving them an innocence and a naivety that represented a new way of telling stories about bad people.

Tabloid stars

The movie frames its characters as tabloid newspaper stars, who are first glamorized and then vilified. As each of their escapades is reported in the next day's press,



Arthur Penn Director

Arthur Penn discovered an interest in theater when stationed in

Britain during World War II. His first movie was *The Left Handed Gun*, a Western starring Paul Newman, but his first major success came with *The Miracle Worker*, an adaptation of a play about deaf

and blind activist Helen Keller that he had previously directed on stage. Penn's most prolific years came in the late 1960s. He died of heart failure in 2010, on his 88th birthday.

Key movies

1966 *The Chase*
1967 *Bonnie and Clyde*
1970 *Little Big Man*